The Backrooms

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There are places the map does not show.

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Preface

Preface

The Backrooms began as a single image: a photograph of an empty office corridor, yellow-lit, carpeted in a pattern that seemed to go on forever. No doors. No windows. No people. The photograph circulated online with a caption that said something like “if you’re not careful and you no-clip out of reality in the wrong areas, you’ll end up in the Backrooms.” That caption — absurd, specific, quietly dreadful — launched a thousand stories.

This novel is one of them. It does not claim to be the definitive account. The Backrooms resist definition. Every expedition that has attempted to map the levels has returned with a different count, different geometries, different estimates of scale. The architecture changes. The rules shift. The only constant is the sound: the low, arrhythmic hum of fluorescent lights running on power from no discernible source, in a building that has no discernible end.

What follows is the account of one person’s passage through three levels of the Backrooms and, eventually, out the other side. The account has been reconstructed from written notes, audio recordings, and the survivor’s own testimony. Where those sources conflict, the account follows the testimony. Where testimony failed, the account follows the silence.

You have been warned. Keep moving. Do not look directly at anything that moves in your peripheral vision. If you hear something that sounds like your name, do not respond. The Backrooms remember nothing, but they learn.

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Part 1 — Level 0: The Lobby

Chapter 1: The First Step

She did not fall. That was the first thing she understood when the carpet came up to meet her feet and stayed there.

She had been in a department store. She remembered that clearly: the particular quality of retail fluorescence, the smell of treated air and synthetic fabrics, the sound of a distant transaction terminal processing a return. She had been walking quickly — too quickly, probably, her eyes on her phone, navigating to the exit. And then the floor had gone slightly wrong underfoot, the way a staircase does when you misjudge the last step in the dark, and she had stumbled, and caught herself, and looked up.

The department store was gone.

The corridor stretched in both directions for as far as she could see, which was not very far because the fluorescent tubes in the ceiling emitted a light that was technically sufficient and practically oppressive, a light that illuminated surfaces without making distances comprehensible. The carpet beneath her feet was the color of old mustard, patterned in a repeating geometric that her eyes kept trying to resolve into a recognizable shape and failing. The walls were wallpaper over plasterboard, a creamy beige that had yellowed toward the color of old teeth, hung with nothing. No pictures. No signs. No doors, at first glance, and then too many doors, and then she was not sure the doors had always been there.

She stood still for a long time.

Chapter 2: The Sound

The hum was the second thing she noticed, after the impossibility of the place had absorbed most of her immediate cognitive capacity. It was not loud. It was the frequency of fluorescent lighting, that particular 60-hertz drone that ordinarily sits below conscious attention and only surfaces when a building has been empty long enough that the hum is the loudest thing in it. Here it was always the loudest thing. She could not locate its source. Every tube, every section of corridor, every room she pushed a door open and peered into: the hum was the same volume, the same pitch, sourceless and omnipresent, as though the Backrooms themselves were vibrating at a frequency just above the threshold of structural resonance.

She would learn later, from accounts she found scratched into the plasterboard in places where other wanderers had stopped to mark their passage, that the hum never stopped. It was the single most consistent feature of Level 0. Entities came and went. Geometry shifted. The wallpaper pattern changed its dominant color across different regions she would later understand as zones. But the hum remained.

She told herself it was a comfort. After three days she believed it.

Chapter 3: Orientation

The rules of Level 0, as she worked them out over the first week:

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Food and water were problems. She found a vending machine on the second day, the face of it cracked at one corner, the mechanism still operational. It accepted nothing but dispensed at random: crackers in the paper sleeves common to institutional breakrooms, small bottles of water, and occasionally a can of a beverage that smelled faintly of almonds and tasted of nothing she could precisely identify. She drank it anyway. She felt better than she had a right to.

Direction was a problem. Level 0's geometry did not obey Euclidean expectations. She mapped as she moved, marking walls with a pen she'd had in her jacket pocket, but the marks were not always where she expected them when she retraced a route. Whether the architecture was genuinely changing or whether her own spatial perception was degrading, she could not determine. She stopped trusting her mapped routes and started trusting her instincts instead, which was terrifying. Her instincts, improbably, proved more reliable.

She was not alone. That was both the most frightening discovery and, ultimately, the one that would save her. The sound she heard on the fourth night — a soft, unhurried something moving on the carpet two corridors over, a sound that was not quite footsteps because footsteps imply a foot, and whatever was making that sound was making contact with the carpet in a distributed, irregular way that suggested nothing human — was the first entity. She did not see it. She pressed herself into a corner behind a door and held her breath and it passed, and the hum absorbed what might have been the sound of its breathing, and it was gone.

She moved differently after that.

Part 2 — Level 1: Pipe Dreams

Chapter 4: The Crossing

She found the transition to Level 1 by accident, which was the only way anyone found it.

She had been following a long corridor that had been running northeast by her estimate for most of a day — she had long since lost reliable track of time, the fluorescent light being seasonal-affective-disorder-constant, never dimming, never brightening, giving no signal — when she noticed that the carpet had changed. Not the pattern. The texture. It was the same unhappy mustard, the same insistent geometry, but it was no longer soft underfoot. It had compressed into something almost rigid, and when she pressed her palm to it she could feel through the backing the faint vibration of pipes.

The walls here were concrete, not plasterboard. The ceiling was lower. The hum was still present but it had a different harmonic now, layered over something that might have been the movement of water or the movement of something else through the pipes whose presence she felt but could not see.

The lights here were not fluorescent tubes. They were bare incandescent bulbs, strung at intervals of approximately four meters, the wire looping in long catenary curves between brackets sunk into the concrete. The light was warmer and less reliable. Some bulbs had failed. Some were in the process of

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failing, cycling through a slow orange fade that she tried not to watch because watching it made the darkness that followed feel permanent.

This was Level 1.

Chapter 5: Water and Warmth

The pipes were real. She found where they emerged from the concrete: runs of industrial galvanized steel, some as wide as her forearm, some as narrow as her thumb, running in parallel along the ceiling and then branching down to junction boxes that connected to nothing visible. She pressed her palm against one and felt heat. Not scalding. Not even uncomfortable. The warmth of a domestic radiator, steady and mechanical, carrying the memory of a boiler somewhere in the infrastructure of this place.

She sat with her back against a warm pipe for a long time and let herself feel something other than cold.

Level 1 had more water than Level 0. She found it standing in low depressions in the concrete floor, pooled and still, with the faint almond odor she had come to associate with the vending machine cans. She drank from it despite every piece of conventional wisdom she possessed about drinking standing water in enclosed spaces. She was thirsty enough. She was still standing afterward, which was its own kind of evidence.

The entities of Level 1 were different from Level 0’s corridor-walker. They were smaller and faster and they moved in groups, and they communicated in a register just above the range of the pipes’ ambient noise in a way that made them hard to locate by sound alone. She saw one clearly once: a thing about the size of a large cat but with the body plan of neither cat nor any other animal she recognized, pale and smooth and moving with the peculiar mechanical fluency of something that had never learned to hesitate. It saw her. It stopped. It made the sound. Then it moved on, and the group moved with it.

She did not understand why it had left her alone. She was grateful that she could not understand it.

Chapter 6: The Other Wanderers

The note was written on the back of a logistics label, the kind used for warehouse inventory, stuck to a junction box with a strip of electrical tape. The handwriting was small and careful: “Level 2 accessible via the maintenance corridor on the east wall of the large room. Room has a broken bulb at the entrance. Do not stop moving through the room. There is something in the ceiling.”

She read it three times.

She had been alone for eleven days by her estimate. The note was the first evidence that another person had passed through this specific point. She did not know when it had been written. The ink was not faded but in Level 1 light was not reliable enough to read degradation. The label’s adhesive had dried and re-set in the way adhesives do over weeks rather than days.

She wrote beneath the note, in the margin of the label: “Arrived from Level 0 northeast corridor. Found water. Entities present but not aggressive when moving. Still here. Still going.”

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She dated it as best she could. She did not know if anyone would ever read it. She wrote it anyway because writing it made her real in a way that the Backrooms, with their determination to be limitless and undifferentiated, were constantly working to undo.

She found the large room. She found the broken bulb. She moved through without stopping.

Part 3 — The Descent

Chapter 7: What Lies Below

She did not expect Level 2 to be dark.

She had come to understand the Backrooms as a place that was committed to a certain kind of light: institutional, sourceless, eternal. It was one of the handful of certainties she had accumulated. So when she stepped through the maintenance corridor and felt the air change — colder, damper, carrying a mineral quality that suggested underground rather than simply enclosed — and looked ahead into genuine, thorough darkness, she felt something she had not felt since the first minutes in Level 0.

She felt like a child.

Her phone was dead. She had a small LED flashlight she had found in a maintenance cabinet in Level 1, the kind that took two AA batteries and produced a cone of white light approximately six feet in diameter. The batteries would last, she estimated, another eight hours if she used it continuously. She had no additional batteries.

Eight hours. She turned the flashlight on and started walking.

Level 2 was industrial in scale. The ceiling, when her light reached it, was high enough to suggest a warehouse or a production floor, hung with ductwork and cable trays and the remnants of a lighting system that had failed completely. The floor was bare concrete, cracked along geological lines that spoke of settling over time measured in decades. Rows of shelving units, empty, ran in both directions, their geometry giving her something like a map: if she followed one row, she would at least travel in a consistent direction.

She followed the nearest row east.

Chapter 8: The Noise

Something made a noise in the dark on the sixth hour.

She had turned the flashlight off twice to conserve batteries and both times the darkness had been so complete — the kind of darkness that presses against the eyes like a physical weight and convinces the visual cortex that it is producing input when it is receiving none — that she had turned it back on within thirty seconds, unable to bear the absolute sensory deprivation of it.

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The noise was high and irregular, like metal under stress. She stopped walking. She swept the flashlight in a slow arc. The shelving. The ductwork overhead. The far wall, which she had now reached, bare concrete with the impression of where large machinery had once been bolted, the outlines of its footprint still visible in the floor.

The noise stopped.

She waited.

It started again, closer, and she identified it this time: a sound of movement across a metal grating she could not see, somewhere above her in the ductwork, something that was not moving toward her but was not moving away either, something that was simply present in the space in the way that all the entities she had encountered were present — without apparent agenda, without the narrative logic that human movement implies, simply occupying the infrastructure and doing whatever it was they did in the spaces between encounters with wanderers.

She walked faster.

Chapter 9: The Exit

The exit was not what the stories had led her to expect.

She had collected fragments of other wanderers' accounts throughout her passage: notes on walls, scratches on surfaces, the residue of other people's thinking distributed through the architecture of the Backrooms in the way that human thought always distributes itself across physical space given enough time and enough wall space to write on. Most accounts of exits described sudden transitions: a door that had not been there before, a corridor that ended in daylight, a staircase going up that emerged into a street or a building or a field.

Her exit was a loading dock.

She found it on the ninth hour, when the flashlight battery was producing light that was amber rather than white and losing brightness measurably every twenty minutes. The loading dock was at the far end of Level 2, its roll-up door partially raised, the gap beneath it showing a quality of light that was different from the Backrooms' institutional spectrum: the inconsistent, variable, directional light of a real source. Daylight. The particular kind of daylight that comes late in the afternoon when the sun has already moved past its zenith and is beginning its consideration of the horizon.

She lay on the concrete and rolled under the door.

The air hit her with the force of a memory: cold and particulate and carrying the smell of exhaust and leaves and the faint industrial residue of a neighborhood that had once been something other than residential. She was in an alley. Real brick on both sides. A real sky above, grey and specific. The loading dock door behind her was ordinary painted steel, flush with the building's exterior, and when she turned and looked at it she saw that the lock was rusted through, the door slightly ajar as though it had been opened from inside some time ago by something that had not been her.

She stood in the alley for a long time.

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Then she took out her notebook — she had kept the notebook dry, against everything, because the habit of writing had been the thing that kept her organized when nothing else remained organized — and she wrote the date as best she could estimate it and the words “Level 0 entry to exit: seventeen days approximate” and a brief inventory of what she had learned.

She did not look back at the door. She already knew that if she looked back the door would be ordinary, would have always been ordinary, would offer nothing but rust and old paint and the smell of a building that had been empty for years.

She walked to the end of the alley and turned left and found a street with traffic on it and stood on the curb and breathed the ordinary contaminated air of the ordinary contaminated world for a long time before she did anything else at all.

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Glossary

no-clip — The involuntary act of passing through solid matter and emerging in the Backrooms. No reliable mechanism has been identified. It appears to occur most frequently at moments of severe inattention, extreme fatigue, or acute perceptual distraction. There is no known method of triggering a no-clip intentionally.

Level — A discrete architectural region of the Backrooms with consistent geometry, consistent environmental conditions, and consistent hazard profile. Level boundaries are not always visible; passage between Levels often occurs without warning. The total number of Levels is unknown and may be infinite.

Entity — A non-human organism that inhabits the Backrooms. Entities vary enormously in appearance, behavior, and apparent intelligence. Most are hostile; a small number are indifferent or, in rare documented cases, cooperative. Entity taxonomy is contested — different expeditions have produced incompatible classification systems.

clipping out — The reverse of no-clipping: returning to baseline reality from the Backrooms. Clipping out is far rarer than no-clipping in and far less well understood. Several exit methods have been documented but none is reproducible on demand.

almond water — A liquid found in vending machines and standing pools throughout certain Levels. It has a faint almond odor and a mild, indeterminate flavor. Despite its ambiguous origin, it appears to be safe to drink and provides genuine sustenance. It is the primary survival resource for extended Backrooms expeditions.

sanity — In Backrooms survivor accounts, a measurable psychological resource that degrades under exposure to entities, environmental anomalies, and extended isolation. When a wanderer’s sanity is sufficiently depleted, perceptual distortions begin, judgment fails, and the risk of fatal decision-making increases substantially. The relationship between Backrooms-induced psychological degradation and conventional psychiatric diagnoses is not established.

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